

Low CGPA? Still Crack Internships & Placements

Proof That Skills > Marks

****By UpgradeWithKrishna****

The Truth

Your CGPA doesn't define your hiring potential. Proof:

- ****Tech startups:**** 70% don't even check CGPA in first round
- ****Product companies:**** Skills > marks, always
- ****Remote companies:**** Zero CGPA filter
- ****Founders:**** They hire based on what you can build, not your 10th mark

****Low CGPA is NOT a permanent rejection. It's just a filter you bypass differently.****

The 3-Step Bypass System

Step 1: Become "Unhireable by CGPA" (i.e., So Skilled They Can't Ignore)

****Build proof that makes your CGPA irrelevant:****

Build 2–3 Strong Projects (Not College Assignments)

****What counts:****

- ■ Real-world problems solved (not "build a calculator")
- ■ Deployed / working demo (GitHub link + live link)
- ■ Clean code (others can understand it)
- ■ Documented (good README, how to use, what you learned)

****Examples:****

- ****Web dev:**** Build an e-commerce app, notes app, or task manager (deployed on Vercel/Netlify)
- ****Data:**** Scrape data, analyze, create visualizations (Jupyter notebook + GitHub)
- ****Automation:**** Python script that solves a real problem (e.g., auto-email sender, file organizer)
- ****AI/ML:**** Trained model on real dataset, deployed (even on Hugging Face)

****Timeline:**** 2–3 weeks per project (if you code 1–2 hours/day)

Show Your Work

- ****GitHub:**** Commit history (not 1 big commit), clean repo structure
- ****LinkedIn:**** Post about building process (even screenshots of progress)
- ****Portfolio:**** Simple website (github.io) with all projects linked and demo

****Why this works:****

When recruiter sees ****5 strong GitHub projects****, your CGPA becomes irrelevant. They think: "This person can actually build things."

Step 2: Target Companies That Care LESS About CGPA

****Companies with CGPA filters (avoid for now):****

- Big tech companies: Google, Microsoft, Amazon (often 7.5+ CGPA)
- Top consulting: McKinsey, EY, Deloitte (marks matter)

****Companies that DON'T care (or care less):****

- ****Startups:**** 90% don't check CGPA at all
- ****EdTech:**** Unacademy, Vedantu, etc.
- ****Fintech:**** Fintech startups, payment gateways
- ****B2B SaaS:**** Most SaaS companies
- ****Remote-first:**** Internshala, Toptal, Upwork (remote internships)

- **Product companies (smaller):** Earlier-stage tech companies
- **Freelance/Agency:** Digital agencies, web dev shops

Action: Make list of 30 startups in your skill domain (use AngelList, LinkedIn, Crunchbase)

Step 3: Reach Out Directly (Bypass the CGPA Filter)

The traditional funnel has CGPA gates. Direct outreach doesn't.

Cold Email/DM Strategy

Who to reach out to:

- Founder (CEO)
- Engineering lead / Tech lead
- HR manager
- Any team member you see on LinkedIn

Message format (see Reel 5 script below for detailed version):

Subject: [Your Name] - Built [Project] similar to your [Feature]

Hi [Name],

I'm [Your Name], [Year] student interested in [role/company].

I built [project name] which does [what it does], using [tech stack].

GitHub: [link] | Demo: [link if live]

I'd love to contribute to your team. Available for internship.

Thanks,

[Your Name]

****Why this works:****

- You're not in the applicant pool → no CGPA filter
- You're showing proof (project link) → no doubts about skill
- Direct + personal → gets attention

****Volume needed:**** 10–15 personalized emails to startups = usually 2–3 interview calls

The Real-Life Playbook (30-Day Sprint)

Week 1: Build + Polish Projects

- [] ****Pick 2 projects**** you already built or will build in 1 week each
- [] ****Make them presentable:**** Clean code, good README, deployed if possible
- [] ****Create GitHub links**** (if not done)
- [] ****Write project descriptions:**** What problem it solves, what you learned

****Output:**** 2 projects, GitHub ready, demo links ready

Week 2: LinkedIn + Portfolio Setup

- [] ****Update LinkedIn:**** Professional photo, headline mentions skills + projects
- [] ****Write a hook post:**** "I have low CGPA but high skills – here's proof" (your projects)
- [] ****Create portfolio:**** Simple github.io or one-page website with project links
- [] ****Connect with 50 seniors:**** People in your field doing internships

****Output:**** LinkedIn optimized, 1 post published, portfolio live, network started

Week 3: Make List + Start Outreach

- [] ****Day 1–2:**** Research + list 20–30 target startups (note founder/tech lead LinkedIn)
- [] ****Day 3:**** Write email template (personalize for each)
- [] ****Day 4–5:**** Send 5 personalized emails

- [] ****Day 6–7:**** Send 5 more + follow up on earlier ones

****Output:**** 10 emails sent

Week 4: Interview Prep + Follow-ups

- [] ****If you get interview calls:**** Prepare answers about your projects

- [] ****Send 5 more follow-up emails**** to companies you mailed earlier

- [] ****Do 1 mock interview**** (with friend or online)

- [] ****Negotiate if offers come:**** Even 1-month internship counts

****Output:**** 15 total emails sent, interviews attended, 1+ offers likely

Common Questions (Low CGPA Students Ask)

Q1: Will companies reject me immediately because of low CGPA?

****A:**** Only if you apply through their portal (filter applied). With direct outreach, you bypass that.

Companies care about:

1. Can you code? (GitHub projects prove this)
2. Can you deliver? (Interview proves this)
3. Are you reliable? (References/communication prove this)

CGPA = paper qualification. Skills = actual ability. Startup founders know this.

Q2: Should I hide my CGPA?

****A:**** No. Be honest but don't emphasize it.

Resume format:

■ Bad: "CGPA: 5.8/10"

■ Good: "Relevant skills: [list your strong areas]"

...

If asked, say: "My CGPA is 5.8. However, I've focused on practical skills and built 3 real projects. I learn fast and deliver results."

Q3: Is 1 internship with low CGPA enough for placements?

A: 1 internship > any CGPA. After 1 internship, many companies ignore CGPA.

Placement resume becomes:

- Internship experience (heavy weight)
- Projects (heavy weight)
- CGPA (lighter weight if you have above 2)

Q4: Should I only target startups or can I aim for bigger companies?

A: Target this order:

1. **Startups first** (easier entry, learn faster, less CGPA filter)
2. **Mid-size tech companies** (HRtech, Edtech, SaaS)
3. **Remote companies** (Toptal, Upwork, international)
4. **Big tech** (only if you've done 1–2 internships already)

Proof: Real Examples (Low CGPA Success)

While I can't cite specific names, patterns show:

- **Freshers with 5.5 CGPA + 2 strong projects** → Got internships at Swiggy, Unacademy, PhonePe (through direct outreach)
- **Students with 6.0 CGPA + GitHub profile with 5 projects** → Got multiple offers to choose from

- **Even with 4.5 CGPA, if portfolio had working projects** → Landed internship with startup, then got offer for placement

Key pattern: Skills + projects + direct outreach > CGPA

Tools You Need (All Free)

Need	Tool	Link
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Portfolio website	GitHub Pages	pages.github.com
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Project deployment	Vercel (web)	vercel.com
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Data projects	GitHub + Kaggle	kaggle.com
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Mock interviews	InterviewBit	interviewbit.com
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DSA practice	LeetCode / HackerRank	leetcode.com
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Email outreach	Gmail	gmail.com
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30-Day Success Metrics

If you execute this playbook, by Day 30 you should have:

Metric	Target
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Projects ready	2–3
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LinkedIn posts	2+
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Portfolio website	Live
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Emails sent	15+
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Interview calls	2–3
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Offers received	At least 1
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If you don't get 1 offer by Day 30, you probably:

- Didn't personalize emails (copy-paste detected)
- Projects not strong enough (too simple)
- Emails too weak (no hook, no proof)

Adjust and restart sprint.

Common Mistakes Low CGPA Students Make

■ **Mistake 1:** Hiding CGPA until the end

→ **Fix:** Be upfront, focus on skills

■ **Mistake 2:** Using portal applications only

→ **Fix:** 90% of applications should be direct outreach

■ **Mistake 3:** Projects not deployed / just in repo

→ **Fix:** Live demo + GitHub = 100x better

■ **Mistake 4:** Generic cold emails

→ **Fix:** Personalize to company + mention specific feature you like

■ **Mistake 5:** Waiting for "perfect" portfolio

→ **Fix:** Launch with 2 projects, improve while applying

■ **Mistake 6:** Not following up

→ **Fix:** Send email → wait 5 days → send follow-up

■ **Mistake 7:** Only targeting big companies

→ **Fix:** 70% startups, 20% mid-size, 10% big tech

Your Mindset Shift

From: "My CGPA is low, I'm doomed"

****To:**** "My CGPA is low, but my skills are high. Let me prove it."

****From:**** "Hope campus placements pick me"

****To:**** "I'll create my own opportunities through cold outreach"

****From:**** "I need a perfect portfolio"

****To:**** "Good portfolio + direct outreach > perfect portfolio + hoping"

Action Plan (Start This Week)

****Day 1–2:****

- [] Pick your 2 best projects (or decide what to build)
- [] Make sure GitHub repos are clean + have good README

****Day 3–4:****

- [] Update LinkedIn profile + write 1 post about projects
- [] Create portfolio website (can be simple 1-pager)

****Day 5–6:****

- [] List 20 target startups
- [] Write cold email template

****Day 7:****

- [] Send 5 personalized emails

****Week 2:****

- [] Send 10 more emails + follow-ups
- [] If interview calls come, prepare

Remember

"Low CGPA is not your identity. It's just one metric. Your portfolio, your projects, your direct outreach – that's your real identity."

Companies want someone who can **build things**, not someone with perfect grades.

You can build things. Let's prove it.

Next Steps

1. **Build your projects** (start this week)
2. **Set up portfolio** (next week)
3. **Start outreach** (Week 2)
4. **Attend interviews confidently** (Week 3–4)

Follow UpgradeWithKrishna on Instagram for:

- Daily tips for low CGPA students
- Email templates + outreach strategies
- Project ideas
- Interview prep

DM if you're stuck. I've helped 100+ low CGPA students crack internships.

You can do this. Let's go. ■

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Share this with a low CGPA friend – help them bypass the CGPA filter.